

Don't Vote for Bits

A paperless office is still a mythical entity, but this year when you vote, it will be paperless. Offices continue to feel the need for paper records, but our General Elections will be conducted without any. Electronic voting machines have been deployed in India since the turn of the century for various local polls; but for the first time, 600 million Indians will elect a Central Government with the press of a button.

Paperless elections have been conducted around the world for a while now, but the merits and risks are still a subject of heated debates. Brazil, for example, enforces mandatory voting for national elections using electronic voting machines.

The benefits of 'paperless' are quite clear and immediate—enabling quick vote counts and eliminating the possibility of ballot-rigging as well as the huge and expensive exercise of printing and distributing thousands of tons of paper securely around the country.

But it has its dark side, too.

At the recent New Delhi assembly polls, returning officers and election booth staffers were unable to operate the machines. At another place, a major party allegedly scared voters by telling them the machines would deliver an electric shock if they voted for the rival party; while the other party was accused of teaching voters to 'start' the machine by pressing their allocated vote button first!

In some cases, ballot-stuffing could even be undetectable. In Tamil Nadu, one party alleged that a machine was accepting votes for all parties, but crediting them to only one party. Similarly, the then Punjab chief minister claimed before an assembly election that it was possible to tamper with the programmed chips to change the votes recorded.

While these incidents may be unsubstantiated, this scenario is indeed possible. Worse, without a voter verifiable audit trail (paper is the usual method), there is no way to confirm whether your vote was counted for the right candidate. While officials may claim that no instances of tampering have ever been noted, that is simply the nature of the new kind of tampering—no one will ever know. Hackers just may find the election year quite profitable.

Just as computer astrology is an exercise in databases and not the divine word, electronic voting machines are simply tabulating systems, and not the solution to our electoral ills. Technology is an enabler; it can help and it can hinder. The conveniences of electronic voting may be compelling, but the prime responsibility is ensuring the voter's intent is not lost.

That remains to be demonstrated.



sumod_hajela@jasubhai.com



Sumod Hajela
Assistant Editor

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